



Council introduces proposed audit of Toledo's Flock cameras

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Toledo City Council is requesting an independent audit of the city's Flock Safety cameras to ensure that the technology is being used appropriately.

The legislation was formally introduced Tuesday by Council President Vanice Williams and Councilman John Hobbs III. The audit comes as many municipalities in Ohio and across the country are reviewing the technology amid privacy concerns from residents.

Council members could vote to approve the audit as early as Sept. 22.

"Residents have expressed concerns regarding the use, access, and sharing of information through the Flock system under the control or supervision of the city of Toledo," Mr. Hobbs said. "This audit, we are hoping to have ... all of these things addressed and to be evaluated."

Flock Safety's automated license plate recognition cameras photograph passing vehicles, recognize license plates and vehicle identifiers, and store that information in a database. The company's software allows officers to search for vehicles and receive real-time alerts if they match a vehicle sought by police.

If approved, the audit would evaluate policies, procedures, and controls that have been used to ensure the information accessed, searched, shared, retained, and used via the Flock system is for authorized and appropriate purposes.

Additionally, some of the other items the auditor could review as authorized by the proposed legislation include:

- Searches performed by city personnel
- Searches of the city's Flock network or data by outside agencies
- Network-sharing arrangements and controls governing access by outside agencies
- Data-retention requirements
- Policies, procedures, training, and other requirements governing use of the technology
- Controls designed to identify unauthorized or inappropriate use
- Compliance with the city's policies

The city auditor, who is independent of the city, and works for city council, will conduct the review.

Mr. Hobbs said the audit could be complete as soon as the end of October.

The proposed legislation would not pause the cameras while the audit is performed, despite [requests](#) from several council members.

"I think it is imperative, at this point, that the administration pause the use of this technology until we find out how to better protect our residents, who I think, are very clear on this topic," Councilman Nick Komives said at a council meeting last week.

Section 30 of the Toledo Municipal Code states that council members can not interfere, directly or indirectly, with the conduct of the mayor's administration.

While a council member could request to pause the cameras, they cannot require it.

Both Mr. Hobbs and Ms. Williams have spoken in support of the technology, and the Toledo Police Department has continuously stated it is an essential tool for investigations.

Still, there have been instances of misuse in other cities.

Columbus has paused its cameras amid an investigation into an officer who allegedly searched the system for the same license plates hundreds of times. The Monroe County Board of Commissioners in Michigan has also voted to end the use of its license plate readers.

Toledo's cameras will be further discussed at a public safety committee meeting Thursday, which gives residents a chance to weigh in.

The council's proposed audit comes about [one month](#) after Lucas County Commissioner Pete Gerken called for an audit on the county's use of Flock cameras.

Mr. Gerken's staff conducted an initial review of the county's database, and from June 20 to July 20, more than 904,000 searches were conducted by more than 3,200 agencies, according to the findings.

Like the Toledo Police Department, Lucas County Sheriff Mike Navarre has defended the license plate readers, calling them a "crime-solving tool."

The city's public safety meeting on Flock cameras is scheduled for 4 p.m. Thursday at One Government Center.

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